

along to you. Once you find a travel agent you like, take him or her to lunch. Explain that you're retired, want cheap airfares, and that restrictions don't bother you. Explain too that two-week package deals appeal to the tourist in a hurry. When *you* travel you stay longer and move slower.

My travel agent in Buenos Aires has standing orders to call me when *any* discount fare comes across his screen. Once he came up with a way for Vicki and me to fly to Europe and actually get paid for doing it. For a brief period in Argentina, a traveler with a plane ticket to Europe or the United States had the right to buy U.S. \$2,000 at the official exchange rate of, say, 2 million pesos. On the free market one could convert that U.S. \$2,000 into 5 million pesos. Those 5 million pesos covered both the 2 million to buy the dollars and the 2.5-million-peso plane ticket. You were left with a free plane ticket and money in your pocket.

When traveling within the United States, use a travel agent in your departure city. For example, if you live in Dallas and want to fly from Chicago to New York, you're better off using a travel agent in Chicago than one in Dallas. In 1986 my Los Angeles agent flew us from L.A. to New Orleans for only \$89. After touring the Southeast we wanted to fly from Washington, D.C., to Boston. The best my L.A. agent could do on that leg was \$149. It seemed high, so I called a friend in Washington, D.C. He checked with his agent there and came up with a \$39 promotional fare.

When traveling overseas, from country to country, it's usually cheaper to buy the entire trip from your U.S. agent before you go. He can get a triangle fare to Europe, for example, with a stopover in the Caribbean at no extra charge. And plane tickets in Western Europe cost a pile if you buy them there. A short hop Paris-London-Paris ticket purchased in Paris, for example, can cost more than the much longer New York-London-Paris-New York ticket purchased in New York.

On the other hand, local, within-the-same-country airfare is